Do You Know How to SELL Your Building?

NEW IDEAS FOR CAPITAL CAMPAIGN MARKETING

BY RABBI YISROEL DOLNIKOV, *Bellevue Hill, Australia*

Shluchim working on fundraising campaigns can learn from new marketing approaches created by marketing gurus such as **Seth Godin** (author of bestsellers, *Idea Virus* and *Purple Cow*). Godin theorizes that all the choices available to consumers have created a market that is "uninterested" in anything not "remarkable." (His example is an analogy: a purple cow among hundreds of brown cows). "Remarkable ideas," claims Godin, "instigate conversations about a product or project." They create prestige in a community and add value to a campaign.

The lesson for shluchim is simple: make your campaign remarkable! Current innovative businesses aim to have the "remarkable" factor built into the essence of their product, rather than during the marketing campaign. The good news for shluchim is that Chabad projects *are*, in essence, "purple cows," especially when compared to other fundraising campaigns. **The trick is to bring that remarkable essence out into the fundraising campaign itself.**

One way to do that is to sell ideas, emotions, concepts, and visions, rather than brick and mortar; i.e., communicate that you're not purchasing a building; you're establishing a center for living Judaism, a Jewish heritage center, a home for Jewish living, etc. *[As they used to say in advertising, it's the sizzle that sells the steak!—Editor]*

Here are a few additional ideas to keep in mind when you are searching for the "remarkable" in your building campaign:

- Good, even *very good*, is not remarkable.
- "Remarkable" is being memorable, the best, or unique–*it could be at anything.*
- Do not be afraid if some people do not like it.
- Not everyone has to think that you are remarkable, but some people have to *love the idea that you're selling.* Godin calls these people the "sneezers" and they are the types of people that sell your campaign to their more cautious friends for you.
- Your remarkableness has to be noteworthy enough for the people who love it to tell their friends (see Seth Godin's *"The Idea Virus"*).
- You need to be able to describe your vision/concept/remarkableness, in one sentence. *[Some people call it the elevator speech. Imagine you were with the biggest baal habayis in town on an elevator. You have to make your pitch before he gets to his floor. What would you say?—Editor]*
- As Seth Godin puts it, "safe is risky." Do not be afraid of being remarkable. When you make mistakes, you learn; when you stay safe, you do not learn.

Let's say you plan to build a new shul. Your ideas and enthusiasm have created a buzz in the community and you now need to maximize your donations. Two simple but effective ideas, described by Israeli behavioral economics expert, **Dan Arieli**, in his book *Predictably Irrational*, will help. Arieli's work shows how, despite what many people think, we largely make economic decisions in a non-logical way.

The first technique—long used by advertisers—is based on the idea that people have trouble making decisions when there are no alternative choices. Here is one of his examples: *The Economist* magazine is advertising two products: its online edition ($59 subscription), and its online edition together with the print edition for $129. When faced with such a choice, most people have trouble deciding which of the two options is better. In this case, the marketing team at *The Economist* wants to sell more subscriptions to the print version, so they put in a third option–a print edition for $119. Studies show that now, with another source of comparison, most people will choose the subscription of print plus online editions for $129. Through the third

(decoy) option, the consumer learned the "relative value" of the $129 subscription. The choice became simplified. In other words, while we have nothing to compare the $59 option with, the $129 subscription is clearly better than the $119 option. When I buy the $129 subscription, I feel like I am getting value for my money.

A similar technique may be applied in offering donation choices and the recognition (*kibudim*) rewards that come with each level of donation.

If you are taking a grass-roots approach to your campaign (appealing to many people to make smaller donations), first decide the ideal amount you want people to give. Let's say you'd like donations of $360. If you simply give the two options of a) $180 to have one's name written on the 'donor tree,' and b) $360 to have a small plaque with one's name in the Chabad House, you will make it difficult for people to choose and you will probably get a 50/50 split in donations. But, if you offer a decoy option that highlights the value of the option you want people to choose, most people will opt for the option you want. Using our example, you should offer a third alternative: $450 for a small plaque, (similar to option 'b'). People will now feel that the $360 option is a steal, because they are getting the same value as the $450 option but at a nearly $100 savings. True, you will get few $450 pledges this way, but remember, your goal was to get $360 pledges.

The same idea may be applied to larger donors, as well. When offering donation choices (naming rights, large recognition plaques, etc), decide the amount you want people to give and make sure you give them a decoy option (e.g., $100,000 for a room dedication, and either $400,000 or $500,000 for naming rights–the $500,000 being the decoy).

The second technique is called 'raising perceived value.' There is a reason why we do not mind spending an extra $500 on a slightly better soup for our children's wedding yet we collect coupons to save a few cents in the supermarket. We spend and give based not only on how much we can afford, but largely on how much we feel the value of the cause is worth. Therefore, if you can raise the perceived value of your cause, people will feel that it is expected and appropriate to give more.

A polished, professional fundraising package is one way to get the message across that your project is high-value. If your fundraising brochure or mini-site is missing vital components – good graphic design, well-written text, captivating 3D images–the potential donor will not feel the perceived value. He will think that instead of the $50,000 you are asking for the building, you really need $5,000 for a fundraising brochure.

So invest in creating perceived value, make sure your cause is remarkable and give donors relative choices. While this may take more effort at the start, it will make it easier for you to receive larger donations — faster.

Rabbi Yisroel Dolnikov *is a shliach at Chabad Double Bay in Sydney, Australia. He is also a capital campaign marketing consultant and director of* ***Binyan Renderings*** *— creators of 3D renderings and marketing tools catered to Jewish organizations. Over the past four years he has helped shluchim, real estate agents and developers add value to their buildings with effective visual tools and strategy.*
The work of Binyan Renderings can be seen at ***binyanstudios.com****.*